

Most companies, like Wipro and Tata Consultancy Services, were already experimenting with the work from home culture in India with some of their staff. Over the next few months they are likely to realise the benefits and drawbacks of working from home and start taking appropriate measures to make it a greater success. For a starter, it is quite obvious that work from home saves travel time and expense, and leads to better productivity. It is no wonder that many tools are being introduced to help promote this work culture.

Over time, even if thirty per cent of people start working from home, it would mean a very large number of people not needing to commute to an office daily.



Representational image

Let Google tell you how long to keep washing your hands

The hardest part about washing your hands is doing it long enough. Google Assistant has now come out with a feature to let you know through a tune that it keeps playing for forty seconds. You have to say, "Hey Google, help me wash my hands."



Representational image

Most of us believe twenty seconds are enough for hand-washing to protect against viruses, but Google Assistant wants you to do it for forty seconds to be on a safer side. In fact, World Health Organization (WHO) also recommends washing hands for forty seconds in order to clean them properly.

What's more, on Android smartphones and iPhones, the Google Assistant shows the complete lyrics of the song that it is playing and on smart displays, such as the Nest Hub, it shows graphics of colourful soap bubbles. Separately, Google has also launched a website dedicated to coronavirus. It gives all the latest information to users about the coronavirus outbreak. In addition to that, the website that can be accessed at google.com/covid19 has shortlinks to FAQ pages by the WHO.

COAI suggests lowering streaming resolution to unburden networks

Cellular Operators Association of India (COAI) has written to the telecom department and over-the-top (OTT) companies such as Netflix, Hotstar, YouTube, Voot, and Amazon Prime Video to lower the streaming resolution to reduce the burden on the networks in the wake of people staying at home due to the coronavirus outbreak. "We believe that during this critical time, it is absolutely essential for the streaming platforms to cooperate with TSPs to manage traffic distribution patterns which are likely to strain network infrastructure at a time when it is needed for various critical requirements," COAI said in a letter to OTT platforms. They have requested for lowering streaming quality to Standard Definition (SD) from High Definition (HD).

"This sudden surge in digital use is already putting pressure on the network infrastructure of the Telecom Service Providers (TSPs). The TSPs are taking requisite steps to manage this load and facilitate the smooth functioning of the networks during this critical time," COAI wrote. "It is pertinent to note that the need of the hour is that companies offering streaming platform service and TSPs take joint responsibility to take steps to ensure smooth functioning of the data communication networks to align with other measures being taken in this battle



Representational image

to curb the propagation of the virus," COAI added in its letter to the OTT services.

It's worth noting that Netflix, Disney and other OTT players have already reduced the streaming quality in Europe to prevent Internet overload. They will "begin reducing bit rates across all our streams in Europe for 30 days," a Netflix spokesperson said. "We estimate that this will reduce Netflix traffic on European networks by around 25 per cent while also ensuring a good quality service for our members," the statement added.